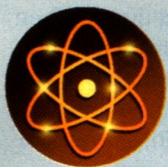




**ON THE US** "The US wants to make India a colonial state and the UPA Government is obliging very shamefully."



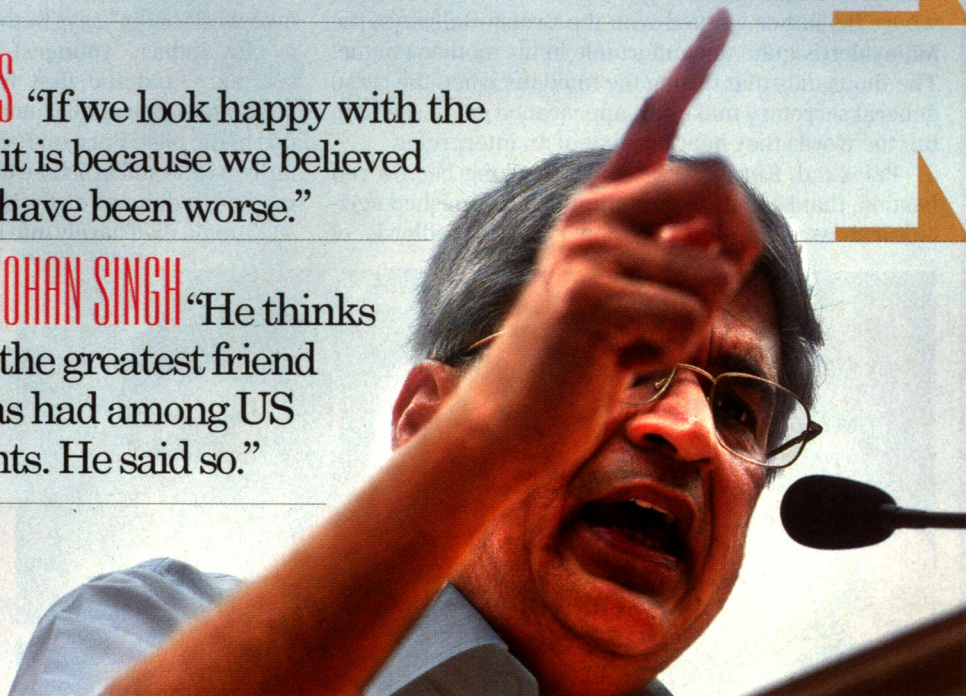
**ON THE NUCLEAR DEAL** "We will not be there to help the Government conclude this agreement with the US."



**ON PRICES** "If we look happy with the budget, it is because we believed it could have been worse."



**ON MANMOHAN SINGH** "He thinks Bush is the greatest friend India has had among US presidents. He said so."



SUMET RINDER SINGH

liver. The Government needs to fork out almost Rs 40,000 crore to beef up the capital of public sector banks. It should bring down its equity and make a public offering, thereby bringing in capital while continuing to own majority shares. But the Left disagrees. The issue of privatisation, steeped in barefaced duplicity, is worse. The Left parties practise economics in Kolkata and politics in Delhi. They find nothing wrong in selling the landmark Great Eastern Hotel in Kolkata to a private chain, but stubbornly resist the sale of the rotting Ashoka Hotel in the national Capital. Since May 2004, the Left has armtwisted the Government to fund sick PSUs to the extent of over Rs 10,000 crore through investments and bailouts. Of the 48 Central PSUs, only nine posted profits while 27 are making losses and 12 have shut shop.

More mysterious is the Left's stand on big retail. It has been proved the world over that retail chains provide opportunity for creation of logistics and supply chain networks, which in turn enables perishables to be stocked and helps curb both wastage and inflationary tendencies. Every year food produce worth Rs 59,000 crore is wasted and much of this loss is borne by farmers. It is also a fact that retail chains create employment at various levels and control migration from villages to cities. And of course, the chains bring affordability to consumers by bringing down

prices. It should ideally form part of the Left manifesto, but they would have none of it.

The hypocrisy is just as obvious in the case of Special Economic Zones (SEZs). The communists chose to stay silent till the farmers in West Bengal began protesting against land acquisition. Clearly, the state Government is desperate for investments, which would create employment and generate revenue to pay for the ever-enlarging bureaucracy. Even on the issue of land for industry, CPI(M) has double standards. Outside Bengal, they don't want anyone to talk concession, yet thought nothing of promising land virtually free to Indonesia's Salim Group. Even when they did get on to the anti-SEZ bandwagon thanks to dissent within UPA, CPI(M) restricted itself to land acquisition and kept silent on the contentious issue of tax exemption, which could cost the Government over Rs 1,00,000 crore by 2009. Ditto with the issue of tax concessions to industry, ranging from exemption from long-term capital gains tax to dividend tax exemption and tax holidays for big business that cost the Government as much as Rs 2,88,000 crore. Exasperated, Manmohan once asked "if we were promoting crony capitalism". The Left kept quiet.

No Chinese model of "social" capitalism for Karat. Then Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya wanted to do a